After the formal briefing, I entered my bunker and had a hot bath. The water was stored in an improvised bucket made from an empty oil tin with a wire handle. It relaxed me as much as a tub bath or a shower in a five-star hotel! The bunker was heated by a bukhari. The warmth exuded by the burning wood was very comforting. I knocked down two quick shots of rum and some appetisers comprising fried liver, pakoras and namkeen. For me, in that wilderness, it was the equivalent of champagne and caviar!

The company commander's bunker was a huge dugout of about 200 square feet with a small bathroom adjacent to it; it had a ceiling made of wooden logs with about twelve inches of sand bags and earth placed above to give it protection from shelling. It had walls made out of planks of the deodar (pine) trees, which were plentiful in that area. It had an agreeable fragrance of old wood, quite like some high-end perfumes. I wondered if it could withstand a direct hit of an artillery shell. But then I wouldn't be in it, as during a hot war I would be directing the battle from the command post – a fortified fighting bunker.

The next morning was bright and clear. Coming out of my bunker, I was stunned by the landscape. What a glorious welcome. As the sun rose over the Shamsabari range, the ultraviolet rays reflected off the snow-covered higher reaches, and directly hit the retina. I shouted for my snow goggles, and wore them over the balaclava. I loved the feel of the goggles and the soothing effect they had on the eyes.

At places the LoC went along the Kishanganga river, with villages on both sides of the river divided by an artificial line. Entire families had been split into two. Elsewhere, the boundary followed the ridgeline or went midway between the top and the valley, cutting across the mountainside. This created complications of its own. The countryside was peaceful and tranquil and the people were mostly poor farmers. They looked for jobs with the army so that they could have a steady income. Though the area was incredibly beautiful, because of its remoteness, there were hardly any visitors or tourists. It was famous for its walnuts, whose outer cover could be crushed